



Student Protection Plan

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Version Control			
Previous Version	New Version	Date	Updates/Notes
Vo5.1 12-07-2024	V06	12-07-2025	No changes made in the current version.
V06 12-07-2025	V07	08 June 2026	Updated information on student numbers, years and financial forecasts. Narrative on Scope, Risk of closure, Loss of facilities, Key staff members leaving including their mitigations and refunds have been updated whilst Risk Rates remain the same. The following has also been added: Teach out arrangements, International students, Continuity of academic and pastoral support.

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1. Purpose

Under the Higher Education and Research Act 2017 Trent Education Centre ('TEC') is required to have a Student Protection Plan to ensure that students are protected if TEC is forced to make significant changes or to close. TEC intends to uphold the consumer rights of students making sure they are aware of their options well in advance of any possible changes to their advertised course.

2. Scope

The Student Protection Plan provides an assessment of a range of risks that may prevent students from being able to continue their studies. These risks are based upon an assessment of the needs, characteristics and circumstances of the students TEC has and expects to have in future. The Student Protection Plan considers the impact of the risk and its likelihood of crystallising. It also considers what measures we should put in place to mitigate the risks identified and how this information will be communicated to students.

For Year End (YE) Feb 2026, 471 FTE students studied at TEC. This includes 460 ESOL or Functional Skills students and 11 students who progressed to ATHE Level 5 Extended Diploma in Business and Management.

For YE Feb 2027, TEC has plans to recruit up to 751 FTE students. This includes English courses for 470 home students and 120 international students; an undesignated two-year HND in Business (Entrepreneurship and Small Business Management) for 20 students starting in July 2026; a Top Up for 11 students progressing from the ATHE Level 5 Extended Diploma in Business and Management course; a two-year HND in Business for 30 students; and two-year NCFE Level 5 Diploma in Cyber Security (HTQ) and Data Analyst (HTQ) courses for 100 students. This student protection plan considers the risks to those students being able to continue their studies.

3. Student Collaboration

TEC is committed to collaborating closely with students in the development and approval of the Student Protection Plan (SPP). TEC consults students in order to take account of their views, interests and requirements when developing, updating and amending the SPP through the following processes:

- 3.1.** The Student Council, which consists of class representatives at TEC, are consulted on their views about the draft SPP, including any amendments, additions or updates they wish to recommend.
- 3.2.** The Student Council will be invited to draft or redraft parts of the SPP and submit their draft with recommendations to the Board of Governors for discussion and approval.
- 3.3.** Student representatives from the Student Council, including the Student President and Vice-President are automatically appointed as full members of the Board of Governors, which is responsible for giving final approval for the SPP.
- 3.4.** When approved by the BoG, the SPP will be published on the TEC website.
- 3.5.** Student representatives from the Student Council will be encouraged to discuss the SPP with other students in their classes, asking them to read it and give their views.
- 3.6.** TEC will conduct a student survey on the SPP three months after the SPP has been published on the website. The purpose of the survey will be to ensure that student views, interests and needs are accounted for adequately in the SPP.
- 3.7.** After compiling student views on the SPP through the student survey, the SPP may be amended if required and sent to the SMT and Student Council for consideration, before being passed to the BoG for final approval.

4. SPP Production Process

- 4.1. The first draft of the Student Protection Plan (SPP) has been produced by TEC Head of Quality and submitted to the Senior Management Team (SMT) and the Student Council for discussion, amendments and recommendations.
- 4.2. The Student Council is invited to submit their own draft of the SPP if they wish.
- 4.3. The second draft of the SPP, incorporating all the amendments and recommendations of the SMT and Student Council will be passed to the Board of Governors (BoG) for final approval.
- 4.4. The final version of the SPP is published on the TEC website.
- 4.5. A student survey is conducted about the SPP.
- 4.6. The SPP may be amended, following discussion by the SMT and the Student Council, and submitted to the BoG for approval.
- 4.7. The Audit & Risk Committee (AR) monitors the SPP, three times per year and reports on mitigations for each risk to the BoG.
- 4.8. The SPP is reviewed and updated annually by the SMT, and the Student Council with final approval by the BoG.

5. Risk to the Continuation of Study

The risk of students being unable to continue their studies for the next two years is based upon how likely the risk will crystallize multiplied by the impact that the risk will have. A Likert scale of 1-5 is used to measure both risk factors, where 1 is very low and 5 is very high. After multiplying both factors together, the overall risk is scored as followed:

Very Low	1-5
Low	6-10
Medium	11-15
High	16-20
Very High	21-25

(1) TEC having to close down due to lack of funds (Very Low)

TEC has been operating since 2012 and has grown from one study centre in Nottingham to having two more in Leicester and Birmingham. TEC has also acquired a new Study Centre at Caste Boulevard for its English language courses. Having a study centre in three cities in the UK helps TEC to spread its risk. TEC has multiple income streams to ensure it remains solvent, professional and reliable staff and satisfied students showing it is sustainable. TEC recently attained ASIC accreditation for all its provision and British Council Accreditation for its English language provision. TEC has plans to run HND in Business and Cyber Security and Data Analyst courses in addition to English language courses for international students, which will provide further revenues to sustain TEC. TEC marketing team have received many enquiries showing an increased demand for TEC's provision in all three of its Study Centre locations. TEC is also actively seeking a university partnership as well as registration with the Office for Students which will allow TEC to run designated higher education courses. TEC has other income streams from a Service Level Agreement and Rent from other providers. TEC has maintained a surplus in previous years, and its financial forecasts show surpluses and a minimum of 30 cash days in hand for the next three years (2027-2029). For these reasons the risk that TEC will have to close down for lack of funds is very low.

(2) Loss of an awarding organisation (NCFE, ATHE or Pearson, BIIAB) (Very Low)

TEC has received very good External Quality Assurance (EQA) reports and Annual Monitoring Reviews (AMRs) from ATHE, NCFE and BIIAB awarding organisations and there is very little risk that TEC will lose an awarding organisation. The ATHE Level 4 group of 16 students all completed successfully. TEC has approval to run the Pearson BTEC HND in Business and is about to start teaching HND in Business (Entrepreneurship and Small Business Management). Given the careful preparations it is making for this the risk of not being successful or having Pearson approval withdrawn is very low.

(3) Loss of facilities (Very Low)

TEC has Study Centres in three cities. Two Study Centres are owned by Trent Property Group Limited, a company wholly owned by the Managing Director (ZA), and there is a five-year lease on all other TEC properties. TEC has been able to rent its properties to other providers when they are not in use, and this has ensured that TEC maintains a healthy capacity in its estates.

(4) Changes to course content (Low)

Course curriculum and assessment materials will be set by awarding organisations, who are responsible for ensuring that qualifications are aligned with the Framework for Higher Education and consistent with threshold standards. The risk that TEC will face challenges with course content is low, but not very low as TEC will be developing higher education courses and may be working with university partners. TEC has a robust governance and academic management framework (GAMF) that will ensure proper monitoring of all course content before and during delivery. The Academic Board, in particular, will oversee the setting up of all new higher education programmes with full reports from the Head of Higher Education and Higher Education Programme Leader(s) submitted to the Academic Board chaired by the Executive Principal.

(5) Key staff members leaving (Medium)

TEC has a very good team of staff, and many have worked at TEC for more than two years, whilst some have worked there since it was established in 2012. However, TEC plans to recruit 3,359 FE and HE students over the next three years as follows: 751 in 2026/27; 1,075 in 2027/28; and 1,533 in 2028/29. This means many new academic staff will need to be recruited especially to maintain a minimum 30:1 Student to Staff Ratio (SSR). This could pose a risk to TEC if a large number of the newly recruited staff were to leave at one time leaving TEC unable to run its courses effectively. This could force TEC to close courses until new staff have been replaced. As TEC has not recruited students at this scale before and has not delivered higher education, this risk is considered medium.

6. Measures to Mitigate Risks

(1) TEC having to close down due to lack of funds (Very Low)

The risk that TEC would be unable to operate due to a lack of revenue is very low. However, to mitigate this, TEC's Executive Finance Committee provides quarterly reports on TEC's financial situation. TEC has also conducted worst case scenario tests to ensure that TEC is able to remain viable. TEC has also attained British Council accreditation and is now able to recruit international students that will provide an alternative revenue stream. TEC has demonstrated that it can also rent out teaching space to other providers if it ever requires further income.

(2) Loss of an awarding organisation (NCFE, ATHE, Pearson or BIIAB) (Very Low)

The risk that TEC will lose an awarding organisation is very low. However, TEC will create a Teach Out Plan if this situation arises to mitigate the impact on students. TEC will make the plan in consultation with students and include options for students to transfer to other providers if they wish. TEC will inform students of any changes as soon as possible and provide full guidance and support about alternative providers. TEC Study Centres are located close to other providers if students should even need or wish to transfer for any reason.

(3) Loss of facilities (Very low)

If a section of College facilities becomes unusable for students, TEC will relocate provision or revise the timetable so that scheduled classes can take place at different times. If TEC were still unable to accommodate students, TEC will compensate them (see the TEC Tuition Fees, Refunds and Compensation Policy). There are other providers close to all TEC Study Centres, with ample rooms that TEC can rent in an emergency.

(4) Changes to course content (Low)

All courses will be reviewed and agreed by the Academic Board before teaching begins. TEC will plan the course carefully to ensure that few if any changes to scheduled classes will be required throughout the two years of the HND. Course Committees will monitor progress regularly and report to the Academic Board.

(5) Key staff members leaving (Medium)

TEC has a Human Resources Manager who is tasked with maintaining a robust human resource and talent management system in order to ensure the recruitment, training and retention of good quality staff. TEC is up to date with all its lesson observations of teachers and staff appraisals. TEC has a resource plan to ensure that there are adequate staff numbers in place to accommodate the planned growth in student numbers. The TEC Student to Academic Staff Ratio (SSR) for all Higher Education provision, including teaching faculty and academic support staff, will be no greater than 30:1 at any one time or location and current plans show that the SSR is averaging at 25:1. TEC will make sure that it advertises for academic staff so that it does not find itself short of staff if many should decide to leave at any one time. TEC has offered a competitive rate to staff alongside training opportunities and membership of Professional Statutory and Regulatory Bodies (PSRBs) such as Advance HE. This improves service level and teaching quality and helps to incentivise and retain staff at TEC. TEC requires Senior Staff to sign contracts with three-month notice periods to ensure there is adequate time for a thorough hand-over of responsibilities to replacement staff. Key staff will be on extended contracts with the standard academic one term notice if they wish to leave.

6.1. Teach-Out Arrangements for Higher Education Students

If TEC is unable to continue delivering a higher education course, TEC will put in place a formal **teach-out plan** to ensure students can complete their studies. This may include completing the programme at TEC with adjusted delivery patterns or transferring students to an equivalent programme at a partner university or another provider. TEC will ensure that students are supported academically and pastorally throughout the teach-out period and that any changes are communicated promptly and clearly.

If TEC is unable to continue delivering a higher education programme due to the loss of a university partner, TEC will implement a teach-out plan in consultation with the partner institution. TEC will ensure that students can complete their qualification either at TEC, at the partner university, or at an alternative provider offering an equivalent programme. Students will be informed at the earliest opportunity and supported through any transfer process. Students will not be charged additional tuition fees to complete a teach-out arrangement.

7. Informing and Protecting Students

TEC develops the Student Protection Plan (SPP) in collaboration with the Student Council (see Student Collaboration above). The SPP is explained to every class by staff and student representatives. If an incident occurs and elements of this SPP have to be actioned, any impacts on students will be communicated to students as soon as possible and students will be informed about all their options. In order to mitigate disruption, TEC will offer students the opportunity to join another TEC course or go to another provider if they wish.

8. International Students

TEC recognises that international students may face additional risks if their course is disrupted, including visa compliance requirements. TEC will provide tailored guidance to international students on attendance, reporting duties, and the implications of transferring to another provider. TEC will work with students to minimise any impact on their visa status and ensure they receive timely information to meet UKVI requirements where necessary. UKVI will be kept informed of any material changes to courses affecting international students.

9. Continuity of Academic and Pastoral Support

During any disruption, TEC will ensure that academic support, pastoral care, welfare services, and learning resources remain available to students. This includes access to tutors, academic skills support, safeguarding services, and student advice. Where delivery locations or timetables change, TEC will ensure that equivalent support is maintained so that students are not disadvantaged. TEC will ensure that assessment opportunities remain available during any disruption so that students can progress and complete their studies.

10. Refunds and Compensation

If a student transfers to another course or provider, the student may claim a refund of tuition fees as explained in the TEC Tuition Fees, Refunds and Compensation Policy. Students may also refer to this policy if they feel that they have been put at a disadvantage due to the change(s) and wish to claim compensation.

TEC will provide refunds or compensation where students suffer a demonstrable financial loss because TEC is unable to preserve continuation of study. Compensation may be offered where students experience additional costs, such as travel or accommodation expenses, arising from changes to delivery. All decisions will follow the principles set out in the TEC Tuition Fees, Refunds and Compensation Policy and will be based on fairness, proportionality, and the individual circumstances of each student.

11. Communication Feedback and Review

TEC will make the Student Protection Plan and Tuition Fees, Refunds and Compensation Policy available on TEC's website.

Students will be kept informed about the plan if it is needed through the Student Council, visiting classes, emails and announcements.

Students will be invited to give feedback on the plan in student surveys, and during meetings and by sending emails. Students can complain to TEC about the plan or its implementation using the Complaints Policy on TEC's website.

The Student Protection Plan will be reviewed every year as a minimum. However, it may be reviewed and revised any time there is significant change at TEC.

Students may also use the Complaints Policy if they are dissatisfied with the implementation of this plan.

12. Results

No.	Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Total	Risk
1	TEC having to close down due to lack of funds	1	5	5	Very Low
2	Loss of an awarding organisation NCFE, ATHE, Pearson, BIIAB	1	3	3	Very Low
3	Loss of facilities	2	2	4	Very Low
4	Changes to course content	2	3	6	Low
5	Key staff members leaving	3	4	12	Medium

Key

Likelihood: 1 = very low, 2 = low, 3 = medium, 4 = high, 5 = very high

Impact 1 = 1 = very low, 2 = low, 3 = medium, 4 = high, 5 = very high

Total = Likelihood multiplied by Impact.